

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

Rare Defenses After 1.d4 and 2.c4

Old Indian, Modern, English, Polish, Englund, 1...Nc6, and unusual move orders

TRAINING WORKBOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

Workbook Method

Attempt each page before reopening the matching course-book chapter. Speak answers aloud or write them. The self-score rewards a clear decision rule and the opponent's best reply, not a lucky move guess.

REVIEW THRESHOLD

8-10: review in one week. 5-7: review tomorrow. 0-4: reread the course chapter now, then retry from a blank board.

Use the workbook again after a game reaches a related structure. Real-game retrieval is the final test.

01. Old Indian Defense - Move Order



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

Reach the Old Indian Defense structure while preserving White's central options.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 d6 3. Nc3

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

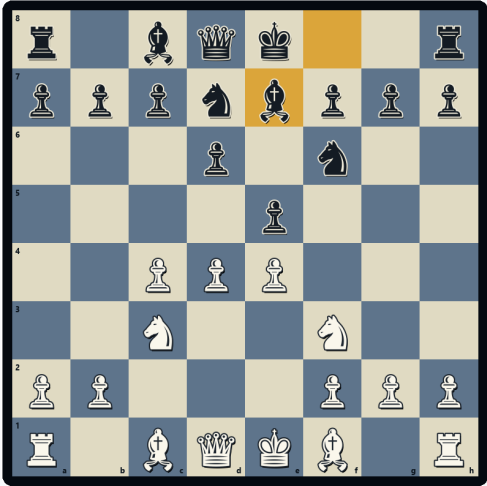
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

02. Old Indian Defense



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

Black builds a compact center without the immediate kingside fianchetto.

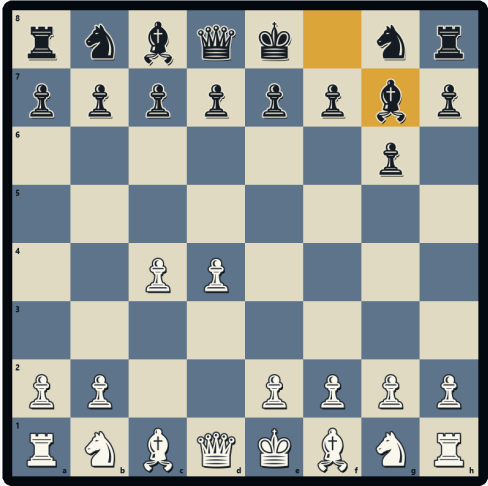
REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 d6 3. Nc3 e5 4. Nf3 Nbd7 5. e4 Be7

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

03. Modern Defense Move Order - Move Order



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

Reach the Modern Defense Move Order structure while preserving White's central options.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

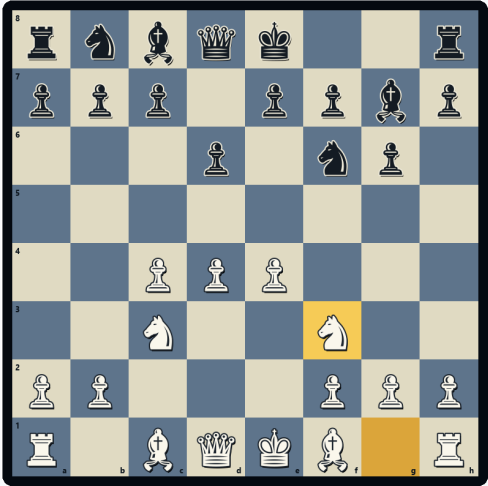
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

04. Modern Defense Move Order



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

Black allows White a broad center and delays the exact opening family.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. e4 Nf6 5. Nf3

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

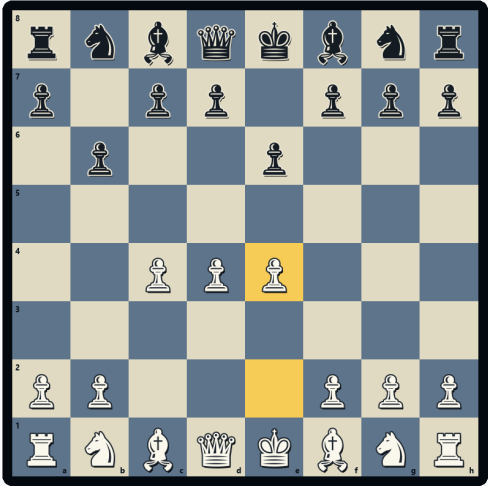
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

05. English Defense - Move Order



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

Reach the English Defense structure while preserving White's central options.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 e6 2. c4 b6 3. e4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

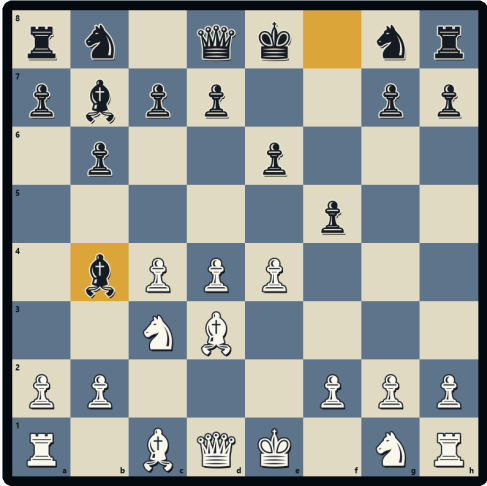
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

06. English Defense



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

Black attacks e4 from the long diagonal and creates an unbalanced center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 e6 2. c4 b6 3. e4 Bb7 4. Bd3 f5 5. Nc3 Bb4

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

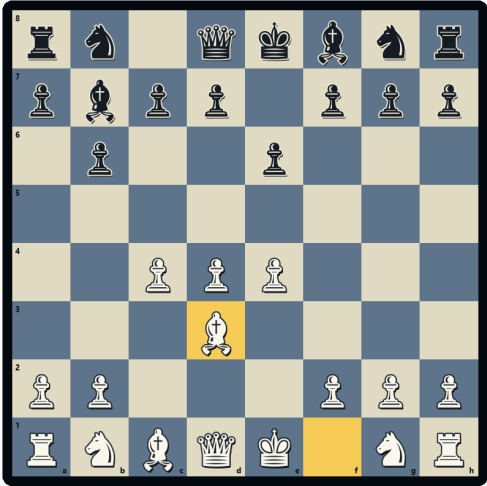
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

07. English Defense Gambit Line - Move Order



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

Reach the English Defense Gambit Line structure while preserving White's central options.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 e6 2. c4 b6 3. e4 Bb7 4. Bd3

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

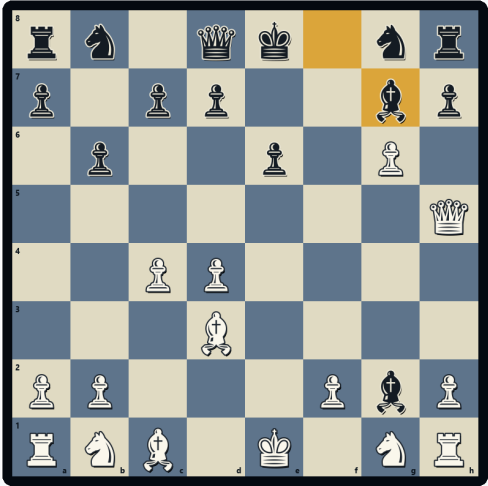
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

08. English Defense Gambit Line



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

The long diagonal creates forcing tactics when White accepts Black's pawn offer.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 e6 2. c4 b6 3. e4 Bb7 4. Bd3 f5 5. exf5 Bxg2 6. Qh5+ g6 7. fxg6 Bg7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

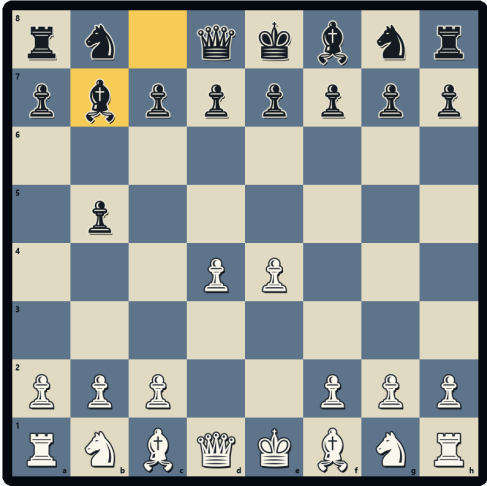
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

09. Polish Defense - Move Order



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

Reach the Polish Defense structure while preserving White's central options.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 b5 2. e4 Bb7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

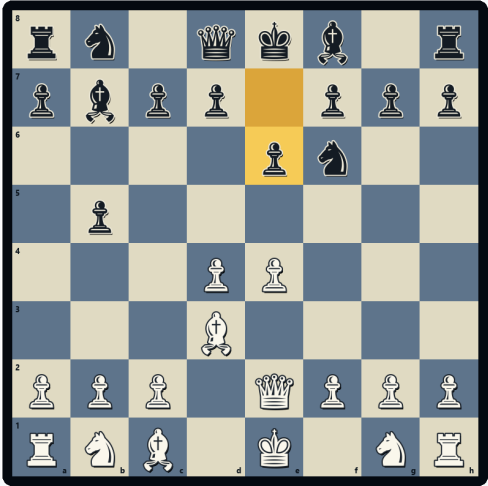
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

10. Polish Defense



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

Black gains queenside space before contesting the center.

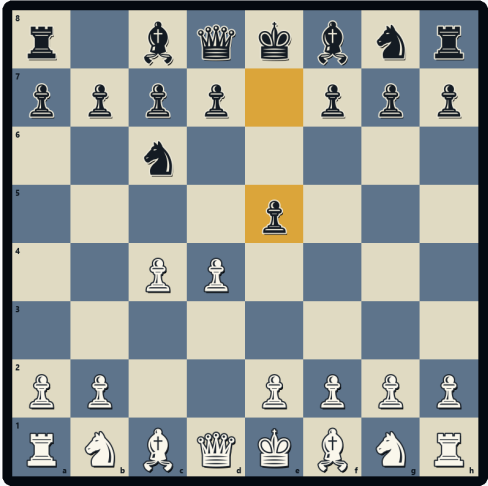
REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 b5 2. e4 Bb7 3. Bd3 Nf6 4. Qe2 e6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

11. 1...Nc6 Defense - Move Order



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

Reach the 1...Nc6 Defense structure while preserving White's central options.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nc6 2. c4 e5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

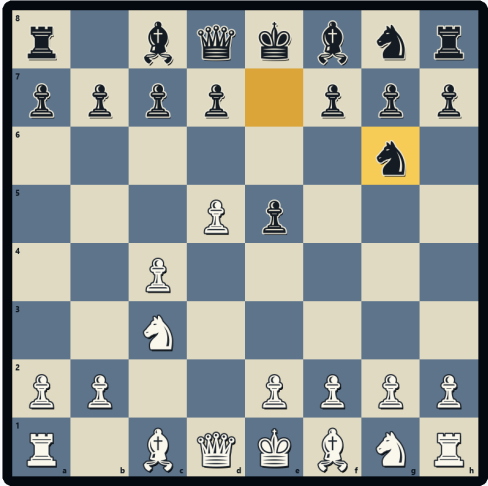
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

12. 1...Nc6 Defense



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

Black attacks d4 immediately and accepts unusual knight routes.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nc6 2. c4 e5 3. d5 Nce7 4. Nc3 Ng6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

13. Englund Gambit - Move Order



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

Reach the Englund Gambit structure while preserving White's central options.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 e5 2. dxe5 Nc6 3. Nf3

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

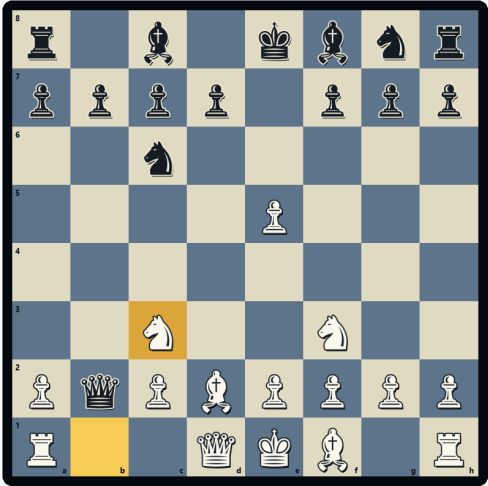
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

14. Englund Gambit



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

Black sacrifices a pawn for checks and queen activity.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 e5 2. dxe5 Nc6 3. Nf3 Qe7 4. Bf4 Qb4+ 5. Bd2 Qxb2 6. Nc3

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

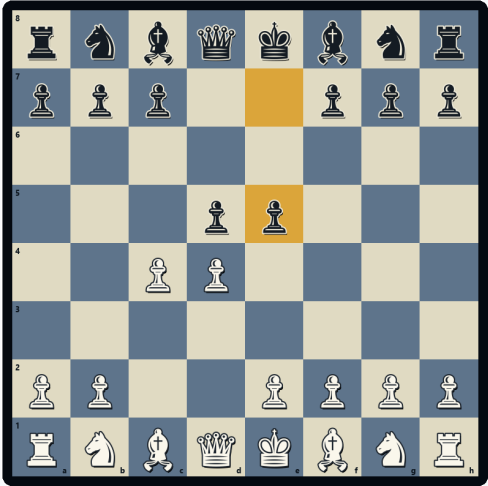
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

15. Blackmar Second-Move Gambit - Move Order



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

Reach the Blackmar Second-Move Gambit structure while preserving White's central options.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

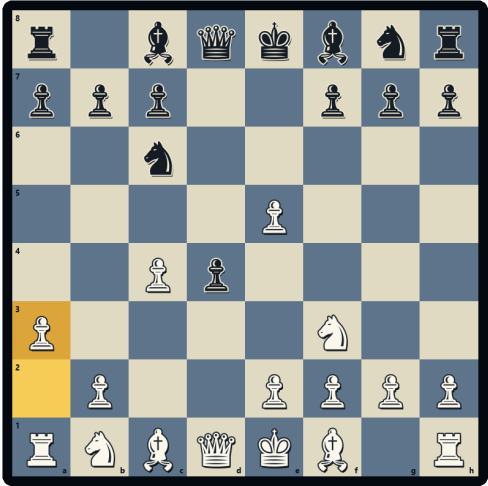
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

16. Blackmar Second-Move Gambit



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

Black uses an Albin-style advance to gain space and tactical chances.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. a3

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

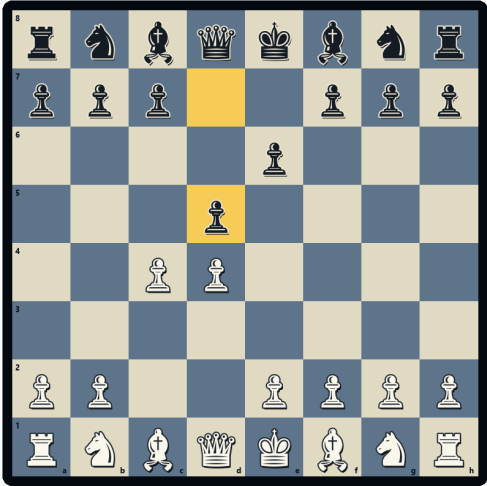
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

17. Horwitz Move Order - Move Order



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

Reach the Horwitz Move Order structure while preserving White's central options.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 e6 2. c4 d5

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

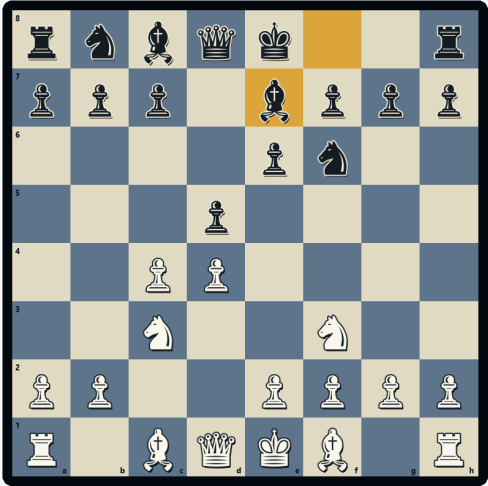
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

18. Horwitz Move Order



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

Black delays the final opening choice and can transpose into several Queen's Gambit systems.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 e6 2. c4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Be7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

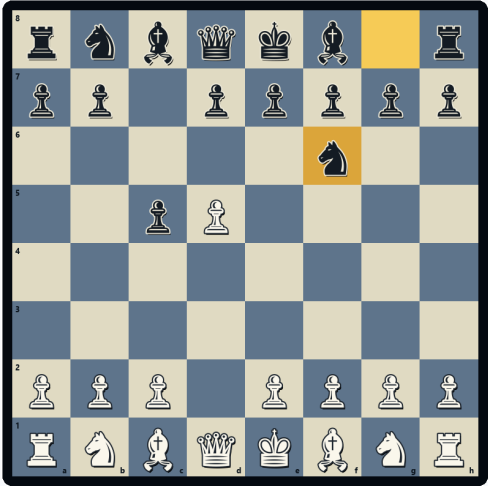
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

19. Early ...c5 Without ...Nf6 - Move Order



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

Reach the Early ...c5 Without ...Nf6 structure while preserving White's central options.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 c5 2. d5 Nf6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

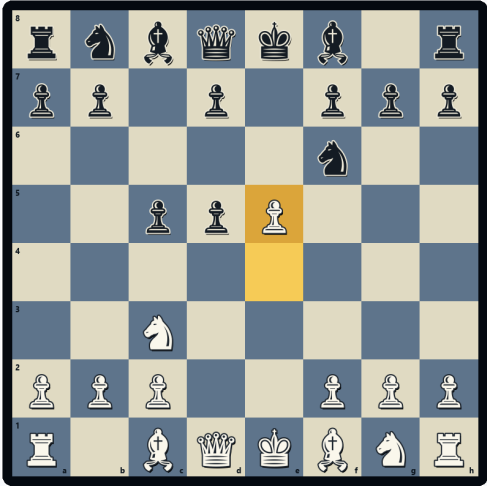
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

20. Early ...c5 Without ...Nf6



RARE DEFENSES

POSITION PROMPT

Black challenges d4 immediately and can reach Benoni structures by a different move order.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 c5 2. d5 Nf6 3. Nc3 e6 4. e4 exd5 5. e5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

Monthly Retention Audit

Select ten random chapters and complete them under a ten-minute total limit. Track the categories you repeatedly miss: threat, candidate, structure, piece job, or forecast.

Do not restart the entire course. Return to the smallest group of chapters that repairs the repeated error, then test again in one week.